

a son's desire for personal fulfilment and his expectations of what he should be. Yet, instead of falling off his pedestal, Gandhi seems to have only reaffirmed his extraordinary relevance in modern India. In not singling out his eldest son Harilal for special treatment—whether it was sending him to England on a scholarship to study law or allowing his businessman friend to write off his debt—Gandhi seems to be mocking the power brokers of contemporary India, for whom dynasty is the ultimate career move.

In Harilal's tragic figure, sometimes a Hindu, at other times a Muslim, sometimes a Godrej salesman, at another time a hoarder of foreign cloth even as his father fights for *swadeshi*, there is a lesson for latter-day politicians: the son of a good man, as the Mahatma says, somewhat harshly, need not always be a good man. But what makes the Mahatma's life such a rich mine for filmmakers? Anupam Kher, who produced and acted in *Maine Gandhi Ko Nahin Mara*, believes it is because of his inherently dramatic life. "Also, we are much more comfortable with ourselves and our history now to be able to explore it," says Kher.

Benegal believes the national stature of Gandhi and Nehru makes it easier for historians and filmmakers to dwell on their lives. "They are not owned by any narrow-thinking community which raises the red flag of intolerance whenever there is new work on them, like the Forward Bloc does with Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose or Bal Thackeray and company do with Shivaji." One of the reasons Gandhi is so potent today is that we wrestle with his ideas in our imagination even as we reject them in practice, says historian Vinay Lal. "There is great anxiety about our capitulation to capitalism, which Gandhi was opposed to, and this is popular culture's way of addressing it," he adds.

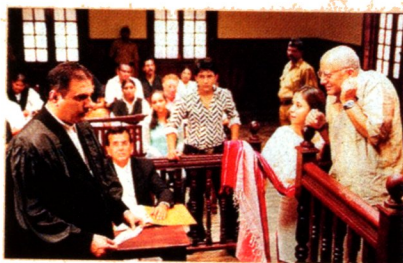
There are clearly two attempts in Khan's film, based largely on Chandulal Dalal's book. One is to show the intimate, human side of a politician who was a remarkably open man, who liked to bare every detail of his life, from his sleeping arrangements to his dietary habits. And the other is to

MAKING OF A SCREEN IDOL

Lost ideal

MAINE GANDHI KO NAHIN MARA, 2005

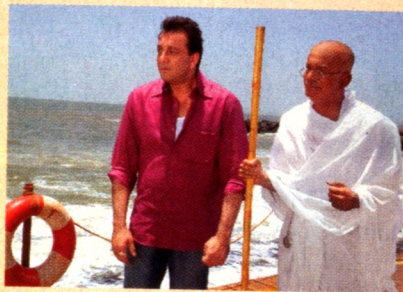
A retired scholar thinks he killed Gandhi when he was eight. It's a metaphor for a nation's tragedy.



Best buddy

LAGE RAHO MUNNABHAI, 2006

If Circuit provided Munnabhai's brain in the sequel where the thug turns idealist preacher, Mahatma Gandhi's ghost was his heart.



A practising philosophy

CHEENI KUM, 2007

A father, a great believer in Gandhi, goes on a satyagraha to protest his daughter's decision of marrying a man older than him.



reclaim the role of Kasturba Gandhi in her husband's struggle. When her son appears yet again at a railway station, offering an orange to his mother, his face wreathed in a beard and his body encased in rags, he urges the crowd, which has gathered, to shout slogans in praise of Kasturba.

Gandhi, My Father's growing triumph also reflects the changed economics of filmmaking. The times have transformed since Benegal filmed *The Making of the Mahatma*. Co-produced by the National Film Development Corporation and the South African Broadcasting Corporation for Rs 3.5 crore, it got a limited commercial release in India, and practically no marketing. Contrast it with the Rs 14-crore budget of *Gandhi, My Father*, which producer Anil Kapoor talked up in all media outlets, and the strategic release he and his partner, Eros, gave it. With 148 prints in the domestic market and 125 overseas, Kapoor is now looking at a commercial release in mainstream US theatres and has hired one of Los Angeles' premier publicists for it. He also timed the release well—though it was ready a year ago, he aimed it at Independence Day this year. It's a flag-waving, anthem-spouting week of willy-nilly patriotism in which solemn statements from Gandhi—such as "my children are soldiers fighting for a new world order"—are met not by cringing, but with a surge in adrenalin.

It also shows that as a nation, we want to believe. In a world where old certainties are fading and where nothing is as it was, Gandhi provides a touchstone. One that can even turn an ordinary thug into an idealistic preacher in *Lage Raho Munnabhai* or evoke enough guilt to prompt us to change things in *Maine Gandhi Ko Nahin Mara*. "Gandhi se bada iss desh mein kuch nahin hai (In this country, there is nothing greater than Gandhi)," says a character to Harilal in the film. Who could disagree?

In an interview while he was making *Gandhi*, Attenborough said Nehru had told him not to deify the Mahatma in his film. "He was too great a man to be turned into a god," he had said. Indian audiences have grown up enough to accept and enjoy the great man's life unravelling onscreen. ■